was significant because the IPFT was one of the key groups demanding a separate state for the tribal regions of Tripura. It had shot into the national limelight in 2017 when hundreds of its supporters blocked railway tracks as well as a national highway on the outskirts of the capital Agartala, demanding the creation of 'Twipraland'. Though the ruling Left Front government rejected the demand, the BJP took a more measured line, saying that it 'recognised the deprivation of the tribals of the state'.[93] Even as this demand turned into a major electoral issue, IPFT forged a pre-poll alliance with the BJP. It was a temporary win-win for both sides.

The alliance allowed the BJP to present itself as a pro-tribal party. According to Ram Madhav, the party first got 'IPFT to issue a statement that they are committed to unity and integrity of Tripura'. In turn, the BJP 'promised the tribals that we would take care of their economic, cultural and social concerns'. The alliance gave this promise local credibility. 'It is because of this partnership,' he told *Organiser*, 'that we won 17 out of 19 tribal seats we contested.'[94] For the IPFT too, an alliance with Delhi's ruling party offered several benefits. N.C. Debbarma, the party chief, said that he felt his party's best chances lay with the BJP. 'They control the Centre, and are most likely to continue,' he argued. 'This is a Constitutional demand and has to be supported by the Centre.'[95] The alliance suited and complimented the strengths of both parties. It was potent enough for the Left's chief minister at the time, Manik Sarkar, to accuse the BJP of trying to divide the state by tying up with tribal groups. This message had no impact and the alliance's arithmetic succeeded in outflanking the powerful Left Front (see Table 16.4).

Table 16.4: The BJP's Rise in Tripura: 2018 Assembly

Party	*Seats*	*Vote-Share*
BJP	35	43%
IPFT	8	7.5%
CPI-M	16	42.7%
TOTAL	60	

Note: Election to one seat, Charilam, was countermanded. Source: ECI